began in an even earlier city, also called Madurai, that was built along the coast and that, like Dwarka, was swallowed by the sea.

This collection of poems was almost entirely lost and forgotten by the mid-nineteenth century. Luckily, a few scholars like Swaminatha Iyer dedicated their lives to painstakingly collecting the old palm-leaf manuscripts from old temples and remote hamlets. In the process, Iyer uncovered ancient religious practices that have survived in isolated pockets in a continuous chain to this day. Still, a significant portion of the corpus appears to have been lost, probably forever.

Sadly, much of the scholarship around Sangam literature is focused on trying to use the corpus to discern the roots of pristine Dravidian culture, unsullied by 'Aryan' influences from the north. This is ridiculous at many levels. First, the society described in the poems is full of trade and exchange with the rest of India as well as foreign lands. It is a world that is busily absorbing all kinds of influences and clearly revelling in it. Looking for signs of a pristine past misses the point about the people who composed the anthologies. Secondly, the composers of the *Sangam* poems clearly show strong religious and cultural links with the rest of the country. This includes knowledge of Buddhist, Brahminical and Jain traditions that are of 'northern' origin. Even when 'local' gods like Murugan (Kartik) are mentioned, they are depicted not as separate but as obviously part of the overall cultural milieu.

The point is that by the late Iron Age, the people in southern India were not just aware of the rest of Indian civilization but were comfortably a part of it. Goods and ideas were flowing along the coast as well as the Dakshina Path. For some odd reason, Indian historians see cultural influences flow only from the North to the rest of the country. The reality was of back-and-forth exchange. We see this in how the 'northern' Sanskrit language evolved over the centuries by absorbing words from other languages. Contrary to popular perception, Sanskrit was never a 'pure' language and its success was largely due to its ability from the earliest times to absorb ideas and words from Tamil, Munda and even Greek[3]. Many of the words that are generally considered as Sanskrit words used in modern Tamil are